Patel’s most enduring contribution to India was getting the hundreds of rulers of princely states to agree to be part of free India. All through early 1947, Patel held meetings with royals who had to decide whether to join India or Pakistan or remain independent once the British left. Along with VP Menon, Patel convinced, intimidated or cajoled ruler after ruler to sign a document that would officially make their kingdom part of India. By August, Patel had been astonishingly successful. The majority of the negotiations were concluded peacefully, but in a few cases, such as Junagadh and Hyderabad, Patel had to resort to a show of military force to get their rulers to comply.



## Partition and Patel

During Partition, tensions were high and horrific violence broke out in many parts of the country, with people turning on each other in a frenzy of communal hatred. As home minister, Patel was at the forefront of trying to stop the violence and look after the refugees now pouring into India. Patel’s actions and thoughts at the time have been criticized as being biased. However, he did not hold back from punishing Hindus and Sikhs who attacked Muslims (and vice versa), and personally visited several riot-prone parts of Delhi to ensure the safety of the city’s Muslims. Patel died in 1950, just three years after India became free, but his impact lives on in the very shape of the country even today.